When the Night is Hard Again

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/50748043.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Catra Has Issues (She-Ra), Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra Needs A Hug, TW-PTSD/CPTSD, TW-Nightmare, catra is touched starved, hurt/comfort kinda, more like hurt/comfort/then BIG hurt, author is going through some stuff so please be nice <3, please read the trigger warnings y'all, right after catra is rescued from horde prime, fluff?? technically, No Smut, short and (not-so) sweet

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by disasterchild314

Summary

After being rescued from Horde Prime's ship, Catra needs alone time, and Adora won't let that happen. Catra needs to talk about what's going on in her mind and let her guard down, who better to listen than Adora?

AKA Catra has PTSD and the nightmares and flashbacks are so intense she can't get any sleep, Adora offers to be her support system (TW in the tags and at the beginning of the text)

Notes

TW- mentions of flashbacks, nightmares, implied/mentioned childhood trauma

See the end of the work for more notes

“Catra?” a soft, familiar voice calls from the automatic door. Her voice makes my whole body curl with guilt and longing. She hasn't left me alone in days. The constant checking up on me is making my skin crawl at this point, but I know she means well so I'll ignore it for now. I curl into a smaller ball, hoping if I don’t respond she’ll think I’m asleep. The figure sits at the end of my bed. I can tell by the indent and movement of the mattress.

“I know you’re awake,” she says. *Well, so much for that.*

I groan in annoyance (maybe hesitation?), sit up, and push the blanket off from my face enough to face who I’m talking to. “Hey, Adora”

Once I completely make eye contact with her, a warm smile breaks across her face and she finally breathes. “How are you doing?”

I dramatically flop back onto my pillow. “Just dandy.”

“Can I sit with you?”

I don’t respond.

“I’m taking that silence as a yes.”

Adora gets up from the end of the bed and sits right next to me. I shuffle around so my back is facing her. I can’t look at her right now. Every time I think of her it’s like nine swords hit my chest all at once. The last time she came into my room, she had her jacket off and I saw the marks– *what I did to her.*

“Catra,” she said. “That wasn’t you. You weren’t in control.”

“But I still did it. I can still feel everything. The bruises on my neck from the implant, the scratches and scars from the broken glass. My nails are tender from hurting you. They ache. And I can’t stop the pain,” I cried (so embarrassing).

She grabbed my hands, opening them up so my palms were exposed, and kissed every inch where the pain was. I can still feel the phantom of her lips in my hands now.

Adora now takes her hand and gently runs it down my arm, small bolts of electricity shooting out from her touch. My heart hiccups for a moment and then I give into her touch, releasing the tension and worry from my body for a moment. Though I'm still turned around, I know Adora climbs under the sheet and lays down by the sounds of the blanket. I don't move.

"Have you been sleeping?"

"What's with all the questions?" I ask. "What do you want from me?"

"I-I wanna know that you're better, or at least not doing worse," she stammers out.

"I couldn't be better. I'm off Horde Prime's ship and not under mind control anymore. So everything is going swell." I continue on before she can ask any more questions. "Don't you have somewhere to be with Sparkles and Arrow Boy?"

"Is this why you've been so distant? Because of Bow and Glimmer?"

"No, Adora." I flip over to face her in my rising anger. "I'm distant because we've been fighting on opposite sides of the war for years and years now. We've tried to kill each other multiple in the past year alone. I almost ended the world because of you. Did you think we could be back to what we used to be? We're not the same dumb cadets in the Horde. We've…evolved for lack of better words."

Adora's face becomes contorted with grief and confusion. Her eyebrows furrowed, nose a little scrunched, and her sky blue eyes watery. *Damn, I missed those eyes.* Any logical feeling I had disappeared the second I stared back at those eyes. Of course Adora thinks things would be the same. She's Adora, she's She-

Ra, legendary helper and savior of the world. If she can tackle Horde Prime's ship and clones, of course she can save us. Please, I'd fold if she simply asked. But I can't tell her that, obviously.

"I didn't mean that," I say, trying to take back my words.

"It's fine, it's fine. You're right anyways. We're different people than we were as cadets. Life has thrown us through very different tough courses and we've faced so much shit." I'd never thought I would hear Ms. Perfect Force Captain, She-Ra Adora curse in my life. "But as I sit here with you, *we* don't feel different, even if we evolved like you said."

How can she be so poetic in times like these? How can she have faith, especially in me? She doesn't know if I'm working with the Horde. But she doesn't care. She rescued me off of her own pure conviction. That's gotta mean something. I don't really know how to respond to her. I can't just spill my heart out. Not now in the midst of everything, but I want to give her something that reassures her I feel the same way.

"I-I feel okay with you," I say, then add: "like it's always been."

She gives me that warm smile again. Adora snakes her hand under the blanket to find my hand, and I'm startled by the feeling of her calloused, scarred hand in mine. I don't think it's the texture of her hand that scared me, but the fact that it is her hand in mine, and that I want it to stay there.

"Did you get any sleep recently?" She must be able to see my dark circles and eyebags.

The answer to that is a big fat no. With the hivemind flashes and other things, I've slept no longer than thirty minutes at a time. I'm so exhausted physically and emotionally that I can't move from my bed. I'll wake up, ruminate on everything and hurt my own feelings, then try to sleep again. It's a bad cycle, but I've been in worse before. Well, this time is different with the nightmares. They're worse than before. The worst it's ever been, actually.

“Not much,” I squeak out.

“It’s the flashes again, right? We can have Entrapta work on the chip. I’m sure she’ll figure out how to fix it or remove it-”

“It’s not just the flashes,” I admit. Adora leans her head in to listen more closely. I take a deep breath. “The nightmares are back, and worse.”

Her forehead crunches again. “Will it help to talk about them?”

I start to argue with her, but I’ve been longing to talk with her like this for years. This may be the last chance I get, so I suck it up. “It’s like back in the Horde, when the memories of Shadow Weaver would replay in my dream. Or when I dreamt that she actually…sent me away. But I always had you to remind me that it was all in my head. Once you left, the dreams got more intense, like the few people I trusted telling me terrible things, and then the flashbacks came, too. I don’t know, now, it’s just awful. It’s never been this bad before. The flashbacks are coming in big waves that I can’t seem to swallow. I haven’t gotten a full hour of sleep because of them. And it’s like there’s constant panic in my chest. I can’t breathe with it there.”

I forgot Adora’s hand was still in mine until she gave me a gentle squeeze. “I remember when we were kids that you felt better when you laid with me. Do you want me to stay?”

I nod my head, letting my guard down for the first time in a long time. “Can, can you do one more thing for me? You don’t have to, or anything, cause it’s weird.”

“I’d do anything to you.”

That warm feeling floods my chest and stomach for a moment. “Will you hold me?” My voice cracks as the words come out. Adora shifts her expression ever so slightly, trying to hide her concern. But I see right through her. “It helps me ground myself, okay.”

"Okay," is the only thing she says in response. I slowly slither into her arms, turning my back once again towards her (yes, I miss being the little spoon). She's hesitant to place her arms on me knowing I'm not big on physical touch, probably why she was so shocked with my request. I guide her arms down right by my ribcage so I can easily grasp onto them and pull them close to my heart. She tucks her head into the back of my neck, and I finally feel my breath slow down. *I've missed this peace.* I close my eyes and for the first time in a long time, peacefully drift off to sleep.

~~*

I'm not sure how long Adora and I have laid together like this, but I almost feel relaxed for the first time in my life. I stretch my body out a little as I wake up. Adora groans at my movement (she must have fallen asleep, too), and squeezes me tightly but gently.

"Are you awake?" she whispers softly into my ear.

"Yes. Sorry, I didn't mean to wake you," I apologize.

"Don't be." Her tone is the same, so light. "I didn't mean to drift off like that."

"It's okay. I did, too. I'm just glad you're here." I rewrap my arms around her's, tucking myself further into her embrace and causing us to intertwine more. Her knee gently grazes the back of my leg, accidentally of course, and an electric shock shoots through the backside of my body. I take a deep breath in and match my breathing to Adora's.

"It's nice, being like this," she admits. I wonder what she means, because it's never what I want her to say. "Holding you feels good."

Heat floods my cheeks. I'm thankful that she can't see my face. It would have been a dead give away. Then again, would that have been so bad? "I'm glad it does. I've wanted you to hold me like this for a while," I admit.

Adora chuckles. “I know.”

Small, not-paralyzing fear hits my chest. I turn my head to face her. “You knew?”

“That you like me? Of course. It was obvious since we were teens. Your longing stares when you think I’m not looking, and when I am you can’t make eye contact with me. I used to feel your wandering eyes in the locker room. But I don’t mind.” She leans over and kisses my cheek. “It’s nice to be admired.”

A smile breaks out on my face, and I quickly bite down on my bottom lip and turn my head back down to stop showing my eagerness. Adora laughs out despite my efforts to conceal myself. “You’re cute like this. You’re wrapped around my finger. I like it. I like our relationship this way. This intimate.”

She kisses the back of my neck, causing me to gasp slightly (I wasn’t expecting her to be so assertive). That eggs her on. She travels her lips around my neck, to the sensitive part right underneath my ear, in a line on my shoulders. Adora pauses her affection, and I turn all the way over to face her. Gracefully and gently, she pulls me into a kiss. My chest explodes with all sorts of new wonderful and colorful feelings. I cannot even perceive how panic and fear used to settle in it. Adora’s light she’s shared with me banishes any dark feeling I’m having.

When we pull away, I snuggle back down into her embrace, and she hugs me once more. This time just tightly, like she’s never going to let me go. A few moments pass, and my head starts to reverberate against her body. She’s laughing, hysterically.

I ask her what’s wrong, and I get a chilling response. “I can’t believe you fell for this.”

My limbs grow still. She squeezes me tighter. That common fear fills my body again. I start to wiggle trying to free myself from her tightening grip, but that makes her grasp more locked in. “Did you

really think I could fall for someone like you? After everything you've done? You're a monster, Catra. And a burden I might add."

As she monologues, I thrash more violently, but nothing avails. She's got me. I'm stuck. I'm trapped again.

"Did you think," her distorted voice begins, "that anyone would ever love you? Your actions are unforgivable. You're selfish at your core, and you've tried your best to hide it. But the truth always comes out." Adora's voice sounds familiar, but it's not her own. It's like two voices being stacked on top of each other. It's a man's voice, and I stop fighting once I realize who's. I look up towards my friend, and her eyes aren't her own anymore. They're green, ones that haunt me. "You wanted your beacon of light to love you back so much didn't you? Did you ever stop to think that you are unforgivable, even to her? Adora never loved you. No one ever did. But you already knew that from the way everyone, and I mean everyone treated you. Who can love a burden? Who can love a monster? You're selfish, Catra. Irredeemable, I'd say. Once you get back to Etheria, no one will ever forgive you. Especially not your beloved."

"No," I whimper out.

Glimmer, Bow, Scorpia, and Entrapta all appear from the outsides of my bed, their eyes also not their own. Prime is them, too. They're all chanting different things, and I can't pick up on what they're saying completely. Scorpia is repeating how I'm a bad friend, Glimmer is telling me everyone is happy to get away from me, Bow is calling me irredeemable, and Entrapta is asking why I sent her away. It's all too much. My chest is heavy up and down rapidly, that's when it gets worse. They all find a part of my body that is exposed and claw at me, like how I clawed at Adora, but without the nails. They're touching me, and I scream at all of them. Too many feelings, too many sounds.

"Please," I sob and beg. "Stop it. Stop it!"

Adora’s eyes fade back into her own. “Oh, Catra. This was all too easy.”

I start fighting again. Thrashing, trying to get one of my arms out to call someone or hit the demons in my bed. “Stop, please. Stop.” I shout. Adora’s and the rest's evil chuckles grow louder and louder until I can’t take it anymore.

My eyes snap open into nothingness.

The room is dark, my breathing is heavy and frantic, and my body is paralyzed. I check the surroundings (as much as I can, anyways). No one else is here, not Sparkles, Arrow Boy, Scorpia, or Entrapta. Adora must have turned off the lights at some point in the night. Just thinking of her gives me a shiver down my whole body, and I can now feel her arms around my torso. My throat starts to close at the realization. I jarringly throw her top arm and the sheets off my body, regaining control in my limbs, and jump off the bed, stumbling backwards accidently hitting the wall. I gasp loudly and cover my mouth, tears now slowly spilling from the corners of my eyes. I stay glued to the wall until I’m able to slow my breathing down. Adora is still fast asleep. I have to convince myself that she’s been asleep for hours. There’s no way she would do anything like that, but my mind isn’t completely certain.

Well, that was some night, right?

End Notes

Okay, just for clarity, everything before the nightmare was real. Adora came in a helped Catra relax (bc she's severely touched starved lol). This scene is basically me just working through my trauma and nightmares so if it doesn't make 100% sense it's whatever lol. Most (of my) trauma nightmares don't make sense but they still suck!

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